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The Journal of American History March 2006 The history of slavery has largely been a history of fields—tobacco, sugar, indigo, rice, and cotton fields. The most influential works on slavery have properly focused on agricultural bondage and how it shaped slavery's development and defined the majority of owner-slave relationships. A few historians, such as Richard Price, W. Jeffrey Bolster, David S. Cecelski, Michael Craton, and Tomas Buchanan, have studied maritime slavery, the work of enslaved people in sailing, fishing, and whaling.² A handful of scholars have mentioned slaves as swimmers, but there has been no sustained study of their recreational and occupational swimming and underwater diving.³ Although most bondpeople were agricultural laborers, that did not preclude swimming. Most plantations were located near waterways to facilitate the transportation of slave-produced goods to market, and rice plantations throughout the Americas were typically situated on tidal waterways, which were vital to the irrigation of this crop.⁴ Thus, large numbers of plantation slaves had ready access to waters in which to swim. Since the mid-twentieth century, scholars have increasingly appreciated slaves' ability to transmit African skills and practices to the Americas and have examined how cultural retentions shaped the development of both black and white sociocultural institutions. Poetry, as

Reading Exercises for the Younger Children in the Schools and Families of the Confederate States (Richmond, 1864), 20–21; William Percey, *The Compleat Swimmer; or, The art of Swimming: Demonstrating the Rules and Practice Thereof, in an Exact, Plain and Easie Method. Necessary to be Known and Practised by all who Studie or Desire their own Preservation* (London, 1658), v; Benjamin Franklin, *The Art of Swimming Rendered Easy* (Glasgow [1840?]), 3–4, 8–9; Archibald Sinclair and William Henry, *Swimming* (London, 1893), 27, 186–280; Everard Digby, *A short introduction for to learne to swimme. Gathered out of Master Digbies Booke of the Art of Swimming. And translated into English for the better instruction of those who understand not the Latine tongue. By Christofer Middleton* (1587; London, 1595), 3–4; Richard Nelligan, *The Art of Swimming: A Practical, Working Manual. Graphically Illustrated from Original Drawings and Photographs, with a Clear and Concise Description of All Strokes* (Boston, 1906); Melchisédec Tévénat, *Art de nager. The art of Swimming. Illustrated by Proper Figures. With Advice for Bathing. By Monsieur Tevenot. Done out of French. To which is Prefixed a Prefatory Discourse Concerning Artificial Swimming, or Keeping ones self Above Water by Several small Portable Engines, in case of Danger* (London, 1699), i–viii, 1, 4–5. 2 Richard Price, "Caribbean Fishing and Fishermen: A Historical Sketch," *American Anthropologist*, 68 (Dec. 1966), 1363–83; James Farr, "A Slow Boat to Nowhere: The Multi-Racial Crews of the American Whaling Industry," *Journal of Negro History*, 68 (Spring 1983), 159–70; W. Jeffrey Bolster, *Black Jacks: African American Seamen in the Age of Sail* (Cambridge, Mass., 1997), 10; David S. Cecelski, *Waterman's Song: Slavery and Freedom in Maritime North Carolina* (Chapel Hill, 2001); Michael Craton and Gail Saunders, *Islanders in the Stream: A History of the Bahamian People from Aboriginal Times to the End of Slavery* (Athens, Ga., 1999); Gail Saunders, *Slavery in the Bahamas, 1648–1838* (Nassau, 1985); Roger Smith, *The Maritime Heritage of the Cayman Islands* (Gainesville, 2000); Virginia Bernhard, *Slaves and Slaveholders in Bermuda, 1616–1782* (Columbia, Mo., 1984); Tomas Buchanan, *Black Life on the Mississippi: Slaves and Free Blacks and the Western Steamboat World* (Chapel Hill, 2004). 3 Peter H. Wood, *Black Majority: Negroes in Colonial South Carolina from 1670 through the Stono Rebellion* (New York, 1972), 123; Cecelski, *Waterman's Song*, 88–89; Marie Jenkins Schwartz, *Born in Bondage: Growing Up Enslaved in the Antebellum South* (Cambridge, Mass., 2000), 130; Price, "Caribbean Fishing and Fishermen," 1376; N. A. T. Hall, "Maritime Maroons: Grand Maroonage from the Danish West Indies," in *Caribbean Slave Society and Economy: A Student Reader*, ed. Hilary Beckles and Verene Shepherd (New York, 1991), 391, 396; Jorge L. China, "A Quest for Freedom: The Immigration of Maritime Maroons into Puerto Rico, 1656–1800," *Journal of Caribbean History*, 31 (nos. 1–2, 1997), 51–87; Bernhard, *Slaves and Slaveholders in Bermuda*, 23–24, 107, 178; John Thornton, *Africa and Africans in the Making of the Atlantic World, 1400–1800* (New York, 1992), 135. 4 Richard S. Dunn, *Sugar and Slaves: The Rise of the Plantation Class in the English West Indies, 1624–1713* (Chapel Hill, 1972); Charles Joyner, *Down by the Riverside: A South Carolina Slave Community* (Urbana, 1985); Allan Kulikoff, *Tobacco and Slaves: The Development of Southern Cultures in the Chesapeake, 1680–1800* (Chapel Hill, 1986); Arthur Pierce Middleton, *Tobacco Coast: A Maritime History of Chesapeake Bay in the Colonial Era* (Baltimore, 1989); Rhys Isaac, *The Transformation of Virginia, 1740–1790* (Chapel Hill, 1988). On rice growing, see Wood, *Black Majority*; Daniel C. Littlefield, *Rice and Slaves: Ethnicity and the Slave Trade in Colonial South Carolina* (Chicago, 1991); Gwendolyn Midlo Hall, *Africans in Colonial Louisiana: The Development of Afro-Creole Culture in the Eighteenth Century* (Baton Rouge, 1992); William Dustinberre, *Tem Dark Days: Slavery in the American Rice Swamps* (Oxford, 1996); Judith A. Carney, *Black Rice: The African Origins of Rice Cultivation in the Americas* (Cambridge, Mass., 2001); and Joyce E. Chaplin, *An Anxious Pursuit: Agricultural Innovation and Modernity in the Lower South, 1730–1815* (Chapel Hill, 1993).